# A-CARD: who we compete with, and where each one really stands

Status as reported in public sources, November 2026. Most sources are secondary (news, blogs, trackers) and some conflict; verify against each company's own announcements before quoting.

**What A-CARD is:** a control layer that lets a company's AI agents spend money safely. Each agent gets its own virtual card or wallet with limits, merchant rules and human approvals; it finds suppliers (A-MERCHANT); each payment is routed over card, x402 or stablecoin (AFP); one ledger and audit log. Rand-first. **Today: a working sandbox on test money, not live.**

| Player | What they do | Real status (reported) | Overlap with A-CARD, and our angle |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Networks and payments majors: the biggest threat, and also our rails** | | | |
| **Visa Intelligent Commerce** | Tokenised credentials so agents can pay on Visa cards | **Pilots.** Live agent transactions with 30+ issuers in Europe (Jul 2026). Merchant product "Connect" still in pilot, no GA date. | Rail, not a rival product. They provide the credential; we provide budgets, approvals, supply and ledger on top. |
| **Mastercard Agent Pay** | Agent tokens on Mastercard cards; "for Machines" programme | **Broadest rollout.** US consumer rollout via banks since late 2025; one source says enabled on nearly all cards (unverified). Mastercard calls some tests "controlled"; Machines still pilot. | Same: a rail we could sit on. Risk if they add business controls themselves. |
| **Stripe (ACP, shared tokens, Link agent wallet)** | Open protocol with OpenAI; shared payment tokens; one-time cards via Link | **Preview.** Shared token in public preview (Apr 2026); extended to Visa/Mastercard agent credentials and BNPL (Mar 2026); Etsy, URBN reported. Stripe Issuing for agents: not confirmed. | **Closest big competitor** for the checkout side. Not rand-first or supplier-discovery; we integrate rather than fight. |
| **Google AP2** | Open agent payments protocol, now donated to FIDO Alliance | **Early.** v0.2 (Apr 2026); public use mostly PayPal and Mastercard pilots. | Standard to support, not a product competitor. |
| **Card issuing infrastructure: suppliers more than rivals** | | | |
| **Lithic** | Card-issuing API | **Shipping.** MCP server (Apr 2026); says agents already use its cards. | Builders add the controls and flow themselves: that's what we sell. Possible partner. |
| **Marqeta** | Card-issuing platform | **Shipping.** MCP server lets agents issue cards and file disputes; AI risk scoring (Mar 2026). Q1 2026 TPV $112B. | Infrastructure, not agent-native workflow. Possible partner. |
| **Spend management** | | | |
| **Ramp** | Corporate cards and spend software | **Early access.** Agent Cards launched Mar 2026: per-transaction tokenised credentials via Visa Intelligent Commerce. | **Direct competitor** for the budget owner, US-first. We differ on supplier discovery, rails and rand. |
| **Brex** | Corporate cards | **No agent cards found.** AI is expense automation. Reported owned by Capital One since Apr 2026. | Watch, not a current rival. |
| **Agent-payments startups: the closest like-for-like** | | | |
| **Skyfire** | Agent identity (KYA) and payments across card, ACH, stablecoin | **Operating.** ~$9.5M raised (a16z CSX, Coinbase Ventures, Neuberger Berman). Reports of thousands of daily transactions (unverified). | Overlaps on payments and routing. We add business controls, supply and local focus. |
| **Payman** | Per-agent wallets with limits and approvals (USD, USDC) | **Early.** Funding reports conflict (~$14M most common). Claims SOC 2, Fifth Third custody, Stripe processing. Few named customers. | **Most similar product.** We add card issuing, supplier directory, rand, routing. |
| **Natural** | B2B agent payments | **Early.** Launched Oct 2025 (~$9.8M); a later $30M Series A is reported by one source only. | Targets the same B2B buyers. Watch closely. |
| **Nekuda** | Agent wallet and "mandates" SDK | **Pilots.** $5M seed (May 2025); Visa Intelligent Commerce launch partner. | Credentials and authorisation layer; narrower than us. |
| **Crossmint** | Agent wallets and checkout, crypto-leaning | **Operating.** ~$23.6M raised (one source). | Overlaps on wallets. We lead on cards and controls. |
| **Crypto rails and South Africa** | | | |
| **Coinbase x402** | Pay-per-request stablecoin protocol; agent wallets | **Real, but inflated.** Foundation under Linux Foundation (Apr 2026). 100M+ transactions, but heavy self-dealing and speculative activity; adjusted volume far lower; activity fell off late 2026. | We support x402 as a rail, governed by our limits. Not a competitor. |
| **SA banks (Discovery, Absa, Standard Bank, Nedbank) and Visa SA** | Consumer and bank AI; Visa "Agentic Ready" programme | **Nothing broadly live for businesses.** Visa says no autonomous AI transactions in SA yet. Discovery Bank has launched consumer agentic payments. Law assumes a human approves each payment. | **Open local gap.** A bank could close it, but is slow; regulatory fit (FICA, POPIA, SARB) is the shared hurdle. |

**Where A-CARD is different**
Rand-first; one product for supplier discovery, controlled cards, wallets and rail routing; humans stay in control (approvals, policy, audit); works end to end in a sandbox today.

**Where we're weaker**
Not live; no issuing partner, licences or SOC 2 yet. Competitors are shipping to real customers, and the networks and Stripe have far more resources.

**Sources (secondary, unverified):** Shatale, ATXP, elogic (Visa/Mastercard status); Stripe changelog and AgentsPay (shared tokens); Ramp and Stabledash (Agent Cards); Marqeta and Lithic product pages; Trio, Rye, BeInCrypto (startup funding); Chainalysis via Bravenewcoin, Decrypt (x402); Google/FIDO announcement (AP2); Stitch, TechCentral, ITWeb, Pulse (South Africa).